

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the second time on 15 November 2022. This tripartite group, comprising representatives of agriculture and processing employers and unions, along with government, was created as an outcome of the Government's Jobs and Skills Summit in September.

Members considered the state of the workforce in the agriculture and processing sector, including receiving a further presentation from Dr Jared Greenville, Executive Director of ABARES, on the composition of the sector's workforce and its use of skills, education and migration systems.

Members noted the update on the Employment White Paper process provided by Victoria Anderson, head of the Employment Taskforce in Treasury. Members welcomed the commitment for the Working Group to be involved in informing the White Paper.

Members discussed the importance of enabling skill development and training opportunities to lift the capability of the sector's workers and employers, including in rural and regional Australia. Members agreed to prioritise further work in the areas of lifting the uptake of vocational education and training and apprenticeships in the sector; improving induction processes, entry level training and recognition of skills developed on the job; and developing a better evidence base and data on the skills in demand in the sector.

Members acknowledged the role of migration in meeting the workforce needs of the agriculture and processing sector. Members agreed to work together to provide advice to the Migration Review on the needs of the sector on issues including supporting employers to access the PALM scheme, pathways to permanency, and protection of migrant workers from exploitation.

The Working Group will next meet on 15 December 2022. Members agreed that issues relating to attracting Australians to work in agriculture and processing and worker protection will be considered at the next Working Group meeting.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Patrick Hutchinson, CEO, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Jannette Armstrong, Executive Director - Farms, United Workers Union
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Richard Shannon, Executive Officer, National Farmers' Federation Horticulture Council
- Scott Connolly, Assistant Secretary, the Australian Council of Trade Unions
- Ben Rogers, General Manager, Workplace Relations and Legal Affairs, National Farmers' Federation
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- Andrew Metcalfe AO, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator

- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-workforce-working-group-november-2022>